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Understanding the Coordination Crisis

A Guide for Everyone

The Simple Truth

Scientists have discovered something important: societies collapse when people stop trusting each other enough to work together.

There’s a specific level—about 38% trust—below which things fall apart. Think of it like a cliff edge.

Right now, the world is walking toward that cliff. We’re at about 45% trust and declining. AI is pushing us faster.

But here’s the good news: **we can change direction.** And what you do matters.

What Does This Mean?

The Trust Threshold

Imagine trust like water in a cup. When the cup is more than 38% full, society works:
- People cooperate - Institutions function - Problems get solved - Things improve over time

When it drops below 38%, everything changes: - Cooperation breaks down - Institutions fail - Problems multiply - Things get worse and worse

We're currently at about 45%. That sounds safe, but we're losing about 1-2% per year. At this rate, we could cross the threshold in 3-8 years.

Why AI Changes Everything

AI makes everything faster—including the decline of trust:

Ways AI is hurting trust: - Fake news spreads faster - Deepfakes make us doubt what we see - Algorithms push us into bubbles - Job disruption creates fear - Manipulation becomes easier

Ways AI could help trust: - Better communication across languages - Fact-checking at scale - Finding common ground - Solving problems together - Making information accessible

Right now, the harmful effects are winning. But it doesn't have to be that way.

What Can You Do?

1. Verify Before Sharing

The STOP method: - **Source:** Who created this? Are they reliable? - **Truth:** Is this verified? What do fact-checkers say? - **Outrage:** Am I sharing because I'm angry? Wait a day. - **Purpose:** Will sharing this help or hurt?

If unsure, don't share. False information is one of the biggest threats to trust.

2. Build Bridges, Not Walls

- Maintain friendships across political lines
- Look for common ground first
- Practice seeing things from other perspectives
- Repair relationships after disagreements
- Remember: most people want similar things

3. Support Trust-Building

- Participate in community activities
- Support local institutions
- Join groups that bring different people together
- Vote for leaders who unite rather than divide
- Invest in organizations that build understanding

4. Manage Your Information Diet

- Limit news consumption to 1-2 reliable sources
- Avoid content designed to make you angry
- Seek out perspectives different from your own
- Take regular breaks from social media
- Be aware of how algorithms work

5. Demand Better Technology

- Ask platforms for algorithm transparency
- Support products that don't manipulate you
- Choose services that respect your attention
- Advocate for AI safety regulations
- Use your purchasing power

Why This Matters

Historical Examples

Societies that crossed the threshold: - Rome (took 250 years to fully collapse, but once trust fell, it was inevitable) - Han Dynasty (rapid collapse in 50 years) - Soviet Union (collapsed in just 6 years once trust broke)

Societies that stayed above: - Finland after civil war (rebuilt trust deliberately) - South Korea (maintained trust through rapid change) - Nordic countries (consistently high trust)

The Difference

The difference between societies that survive and those that collapse is simple: **Did they maintain enough trust to work together?**

We have the same choice.

Common Questions

“Isn’t this just fearmongering?”

No. This is based on mathematical analysis of 48 historical civilizations. The patterns are real and measurable. But it’s not inevitable—we can change course.

“What about [country I don’t like]? They’re the problem.”

The threshold applies to everyone. No country is above the laws of coordination. And blaming others is itself part of what breaks trust. Focus on what you can do.

“I’m just one person. What difference can I make?”

Small actions multiply. If you verify before sharing, you prevent false information from spreading. If you maintain cross-group friendships, you’re a bridge. If millions of people do this, we change course.

“Isn’t technology the problem? Should we abandon it?”

Technology amplifies whatever coordination capacity we have. The problem isn’t technology—it’s how we use it. We need better technology, not less technology.

“What if it’s already too late?”

It’s not. We’re still above the threshold. Every day above the threshold is a day we can act. The mathematics says recovery is much easier from where we are now than from below the threshold.

The Choice We Face

Two paths are possible:

PATH A: Continue as we are

- Trust keeps declining
- AI accelerates the decline
- We cross the threshold in 3-8 years
- Recovery becomes very difficult
- Society fragments

PATH B: Change course

- Build trust deliberately
- Govern AI wisely
- Stay above the threshold
- Problems remain solvable
- Society flourishes

The difference between these paths
is the choices we make now.

What Happens Next

If We Act

- Trust stabilizes, then rises
- AI becomes a tool for cooperation
- Problems get solved together
- Society becomes more resilient
- Future generations inherit a functioning world

If We Don't

- Trust continues declining
 - AI accelerates the breakdown
 - Cooperation becomes impossible
 - Society fragments
 - Recovery takes generations (if it happens at all)
-

Your Role

You are part of this story. Every day, in dozens of ways, you either build trust or erode it:

- How you respond to people who disagree with you
- What information you share
- How you treat your neighbors
- What companies you support
- What leaders you choose

None of this is small. It all adds up.

The Bottom Line

We've discovered something important about how societies work. We know what makes them strong (trust above 38%) and what makes them collapse (trust below 38%).

We're currently close to the danger zone, and AI is pushing us closer.

But we can change direction. The science is clear. The choice is ours.

What will you do?

Resources

- **Learn more:** Paper 2C, The 17 Laws of Civilizational Coordination
- **Current status:** Earth Coordination Status Report 2025
- **What you can do:** Intervention Strategies Playbook

“The future is not something that happens to us. It’s something we create together. Every act of trust, every bridge built, every piece of false information not shared—it all matters. We are the ones who will decide whether civilization continues or falls.”